

851–860



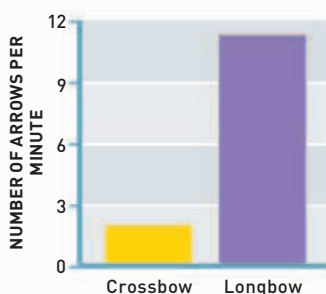
Monument in the courtyard of the Maya city of Palenque.

THE DECLINE OF THE CLASSIC

MAYA civilization continued as the wave of abandonments that began with **Palenque** at the end of the 9th century spread south and east into the Classic Maya heartland. The last recorded inscriptions at Mayan cities Quiriguá and Copán date to 810 and 822; at **Caracol** to 859; and at Tikal to 889. A combination of **drought, famine, disease**, and social upheaval were probably responsible, as overpopulated cities and their overstretched resources reached a tipping point.

The first recorded use of a **crossbow** was in France in 851. Although slower to reload than a longbow, the crossbow, or *arbalist*, required little training or strength to operate.

The **Fujiwara regency**, assumed by Yoshifusa (c. 804–72) on the accession of his grandson, the child-emperor Seiwa in 858, marked the Fujiwara clan's domination of Japanese power.



Crossbow versus longbow

Although the longbow could be fired much faster, the crossbow had a greater range and was easy to operate.

861–870



The frontispiece of *The Diamond Sutra*, the earliest known printed work, shows Buddha explaining the sutra (sermon) to an elderly disciple.



HAZAR EMPIRE

The Caspian Sea is still known in the region as the Khazar Sea for the empire that ruled the area between it and the Black Sea from the 8th to 10th centuries. A contributing cause to the empire's decline may have been a rise of 23 ft (7m) in the sea level.

CYRILLIC SCRIPT WAS INVENTED

by the Byzantine missionary later known as **St. Cyril** in around 863. Originally named Constantine, Cyril and his brother Methodius were sent to **convert the Slavs in Moravia** by Byzantine emperor, Michael III in around 862. Cyril devised a new "Glagolitic" script to **translate the Bible** into Slavic; this later became Cyrillic script.

In 867, Basil, a favorite of Michael III, deposed his master and took the throne as **Basil I**. His reign marked the start of one of the most glorious periods of Byzantine history. Intent on restoring the empire internally and externally, Basil rebuilt the army and navy and revised the legal system.

The **Diamond Sutra** of 868 is the world's oldest surviving printed book. An illustrated Buddhist text, it was found in a cave in Dunhuang, a Silk Road town in northwest China.

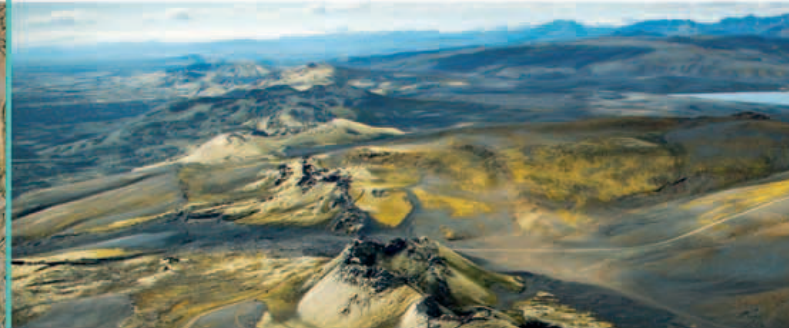
Around the mid-9th century, the **Khazars adopted Judaism** (see 801–10). According to tradition, they chose an **Abrahamic faith** to put them on equal footing with Christianity in the Byzantine Empire and Islam in the Caliphate.



Early Cyrillic script

This wax tablet contains psalms of David, written in the early 11th century. It is believed to be the oldest document written in Cyrillic.

871–880



The landscape of Iceland offered scant welcome, yet Vikings settled here by 874.

ALFRED THE GREAT OF ENGLAND, an educated man who had spent time in Rome with the Pope, acceded to the throne of the Anglo-Saxon kingdom of **Wessex** in 871. During the reign of his elder brother Aethelred I (r. 865–71), **Danish Vikings** had invaded Wessex, but Alfred had helped defeat them at the **Battle of Ashdown** in 870. On assuming the kingship, Alfred averted crisis by defeating the Danes at Wilton in southwest England, but another attack in 875 caught him unawares and he was forced to retreat to the Somerset marshes.

According to the popular legend, Alfred was here given shelter by a peasant woman who, unaware of his identity, left him to watch some cakes that were cooking on the fire. Preoccupied with the problems of his kingdom, Alfred let the cakes burn. Nonetheless he was able to summon his armies and defeated the Danish king Guthrum at the Battle of Edington in 878, forcing him to conclude the **Peace of Wedmore**, under the terms of which **Guthrum converted to Christianity** and agreed to a division of the country (see 881–90).

The **settlement of Iceland** demonstrated how the **Vikings** were advancing on other fronts. Irish monks had probably already reached the North Atlantic island, and Viking navigators had other clues to its existence, such as the passage of migrating birds. Vikings had already visited the



King Alfred

A statue of King Alfred was erected at his capital, Winchester, in 1901. His sword doubles as a crucifix, emblematic of his militant faith.

island and even overwintered there, but the first permanent settlement, according to the medieval Icelandic *Landnámabók* (Book of Settlement), was by the Norwegian chieftain Ingolfur Arnarson in around 874. According to legend, he selected the spot for his homestead by throwing his

c. 850s Continued decline of Classic Maya civilization
851 Crossbow introduced to France
857 Founding of Kingdom of Navarre in Spain
858 Fujiwara regency in Japan; Fujiwara clan cement hold on power
857 Plague of ergot poisoning in Western Europe from infected cereals

862 Vikings found Novgorod
863 Invention of earliest form of Cyrillic writing
863 Byzantines win victory over Arabs in Anatolia
866 Bulgars convert to Christianity
866 Vikings capture York, England
868 Creation of Diamond Sutra, oldest surviving printed book
867 Accession of Basil I, founder of Macedonian dynasty
868 Ahmad ibn-Tulun founds Tulunid Dynasty in Egypt
869 Last dated stele at Tikal in Mesopotamia
870 Treaty of Meersen divides Frankish lands of the Kingdom of Lothar I

871 Alfred becomes King of Wessex, England
874 Disappearance of Al-Mahdi, the Hidden Imam of Twelver Shi'ites
874 Vikings settle Iceland
874 Peasant revolt against Tang after terrible drought in China
874 Persian literary renaissance begins in Bukhara
875 Catalonia in Spain becomes partially autonomous from Carolingian Empire
878 Battle of Edington in England followed by Peace of Wedmore